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Translating flora in the Bible

0.1 Translating flora in the Bible

The dilemma of the Bible translator is that the Bible is both a historical document and a literary document. That duality finds its way into every verse of every chapter of the Bible. The historicity of the text pulls the translator toward formal (word-for-word, sentence-for-sentence) translation. The literary, rhetorical nature of the text pulls the translator toward literary, rhetorical, and poetic equivalence, that is, toward making the same emotive impact on the reader that the original did. That usually requires considerable restructuring and transformation. There is no "happy medium," only various unhappy ones, or rather, unhappy readers on one side or the other!

Words for trees and plants in the Bible do not escape this dilemma. The first question that a translator must ask is this: Is the immediate context of this word primarily RHETORICAL or primarily NON-RHETORICAL. We say "primarily" here because some texts are difficult to categorize. We say "non-rhetorical" to avoid the word "historical" that carries with it problems of determining what "history" is in the context of ancient texts.

One element of a translator's task is dealing with technical terms, and particularly whether they should be translated in a way that makes the item familiar to the reader ("domestication"), or leaves the item a bit strange ("foreignization"). A typical example is in measurements. A Bible translator who converts Jewish "cubits" to feet and inches (or to metric units) "domesticates" the text by using measurements that are familiar to the reader, while a translator who leaves "cubits" in the text is (in many cases) "foreignizing" the text. A translator who uses "figi" (from English "fig") in the text (rather than a local word) is "foreignizing." The "foreignness" of the whole translation is determined by the accumulation of decisions to domesticate or foreignize measurements, vocabulary, and even grammar, throughout the translation.

The "dynamic/functional equivalence" Bible translation movement in the middle of the twentieth century brought a new thinking, namely, "God speaks your language." Radical domestication became the norm. But Bible translation theory changes, and right now "foreignization" is not as bad as we used to think. Too much domestication is seen as misleading or even as patronizing, like "baby-talk." But how much domestication is the right amount? It depends on what the "stakeholders" want. And who are the stakeholders? The publisher, of course, but more important in the long run are the potential readers.

Let us refine the question: How narrow should a translator's target audience be? Which group of people should be taken as the model for the Bible spellings: rural people with little exposure to other languages? Or cosmopolitan people whose experiences (including radio and television) have been expanded to include a wider range of concepts?

Each magazine or book aims at an audience, who in a sense become the "authority" behind that magazine or book. Bibles are the same. Most European and English Bibles aim at people who are able to handle the "foreignness" of the original Greek and Hebrew technical vocabulary. In this Handbook we try to leave some flexibility in our suggestions for a variety of approaches from foreignizing to domesticating, and for translators in a variety of situations and with a variety of audiences in mind.

To be practical, however, we deliberately attempt to be PRESCRIPTIVE, onerous as that may be to some students of translation. We aim mostly at translators who are doing "dynamic/functional equivalence" translation, with a slant toward taking rhetoric and genre seriously.

Publishers have "style sheets," recognizing that their set of rules for spelling, format, and style will bring a certain consistency to their many publications, and recognizing also that their set of rules is not universal. Likewise, we promote a consistent approach, and we make no claim that our suggestions for translating Bible terminology are binding on anyone. We can only say that IF a translator follows these suggestions, the result will be within the mainstream of scholarly Bible translation opinion at the beginning of the twenty-first century.